

Last-Mile Delivery Exception Resolution Playbook

Section 1: Escalation Policy Overview

This manual guides dispatchers and the automated exception-handling system in resolving last-mile delivery exceptions consistently and fairly. Escalation to a human supervisor is mandatory, regardless of any other resolution decision, whenever any of the following automatic triggers apply:

1. Third failed delivery attempt on any shipment, for any customer tier. A 3rd failed attempt indicates a persistent delivery problem that requires supervisor judgment on further handling, even if a locker reroute or reschedule is otherwise proposed.
2. VIP customers with 3 or more delivery exceptions recorded in the last 90 days. Repeated exceptions for our highest-tier customers are treated as a retention risk and must be reviewed by a supervisor before the resolution is communicated.
3. In addition to automatic triggers, dispatchers should apply discretionary judgment: a STANDARD tier customer with more than 5 exceptions in the last 90 days should also be escalated, even though this is not a hard rule, since it typically signals a systemic delivery issue (bad address data, unreliable route, etc.) rather than a one-off event.

Section 2: Address Issues, Rescheduling, and Locker Rerouting

ADDRESS_ISSUE exceptions (e.g., building not found, unclear unit number, gate code not working) should default to RESCHEDULE together with an outreach message asking the customer to confirm or clarify their address. Do not escalate an address issue unless it also meets one of the automatic escalation triggers in Section 1 or shows signs of a fraudulent address (vacant, demolished, construction site, empty lot) - address issues alone are a routine, low-severity exception.

For ATTEMPTED (failed delivery attempt) exceptions, check locker availability at the delivery zip code before defaulting to RESCHEDULE or RETURN_TO_SENDER. If an eligible locker exists (correct size and not FULL/LIMITED-blocked), REROUTE_TO_LOCKER is strongly preferred over RETURN_TO_SENDER, since it gets the package to the customer faster and avoids a costly reverse-logistics trip. Only use RETURN_TO_SENDER when no eligible locker exists and further delivery attempts are not viable.

For a first or second failed attempt with no eligible locker, RESCHEDULE is the correct default. Reserve RETURN_TO_SENDER for cases with no eligible locker and either a 3rd failed attempt or an explicit customer refusal.

Section 3: Damaged and Fragile Packages

Any package marked DAMAGED with package_type FRAGILE must be resolved as REPLACE. Do not attempt to reschedule delivery of a physically damaged fragile item - the customer should not receive a damaged good under any circumstance.

Damaged PERISHABLE packages are handled under Section 5 (perishable-specific rules) since spoilage risk takes priority over the general damaged-goods rule.

When replacing a damaged package for a VIP or PREMIUM customer, the communication should use a FORMAL tone and, at the dispatcher's discretion, may include a small goodwill credit toward the customer's account for the inconvenience.

Section 4: Refused Deliveries

A REFUSED status, where the customer declines the package at the door (e.g., states they did not order the item, or no longer wants it), should default to RETURN_TO_SENDER. This is a standard, low-severity resolution and does not require supervisor escalation unless the customer's tier or exception history independently meets an escalation trigger from Section 1.

Communications for refused deliveries should be brief, non-judgmental, and should not speculate about why the customer refused the package. Simply confirm that the item is being returned to the sender and provide an expected timeframe (typically 2 business days).

Section 5: Perishable Packages and Weather Delays

PERISHABLE packages carry spoilage risk and are handled more strictly than standard goods. Any DAMAGED perishable package must be resolved as REPLACE and automatically escalated to a supervisor, since a damaged perishable item is both a customer-satisfaction and food-safety concern.

For WEATHER_DELAY exceptions involving a perishable package, extract the estimated delay duration from the status description. If the delay exceeds 4 hours, the item is likely compromised and the resolution must be REPLACE, with automatic escalation to a supervisor regardless of customer tier. Delays of 4 hours or less do not require replacement or escalation on their own.

PREMIUM customers experiencing a perishable weather delay should be flagged for discretionary supervisor review even below the 4-hour threshold, since PREMIUM tier sits just below VIP and dispatchers should watch for early signs of service degradation. VIP customers affected by a qualifying perishable weather delay should also receive a small goodwill credit (for example, \$10) toward their account alongside the replacement, communicated in a FORMAL tone.